

Chapter 0: A Meeting with a Very Powerful Man

Chapter 0: An Interview with a Very Powerful Man

Interviewer: Torrhex's predictions for the future have gone through significant change. The greatest concern many have is the one showing our cities falling back down to Earth. What are your thoughts?

Head Coven Master Hadeon: This will absolutely bring the end. What we knew has been torn apart and we will never be able to recover.

Interviewer: And who would you blame for the downfall?

Head Coven Master Hadeon: Salem Mora. If she isn't defeated by next year, I fear what our world will become.

Chapter 1: A Six Legged Cat with Wingss and a Message

Salem Mora
7 Years Earlier

It should have been a nice summer morning, the type that should have told you that everything was going to be okay. The type that told you that after tomorrow, you were no longer a middle schooler. You were a *real* teenager. The type that told you that school ends today, so no more homework or assignments for the next few months.

But it wasn't.

It was a silent morning. A silence that told you everything was going to go wrong. There were no birds in the air. Not even a pigeon pecking at the trash below. Cars were silent, and there were no people walking around. The type of silence that told you something big was going to happen. Something life changing.

It was early in the morning, before the sun had risen above the sky scrappers that filled the horizon, but even at this time, "the city that never sleeps" was usually more lively.

New York City was usually noisy. Birds chirping. People talking. Cars honking. There was always something happening.

Except for today.

Salem Mora sat by an open window, watching the silent city. She was an incredibly average girl. She had long brown hair, and dark brown eyes. She had no interesting birthmarks, no suspiciously cool relatives, no mysterious backstory. She had a bus pass, a half-dead cactus, and a strangely average life for sharing a name with a town known for burning witches.

Someone could walk past her and not notice her there.

It was a common sight to see her by the window early in the morning. She enjoyed watching the pigeons peck at crumbs. But today she couldn't help but feel uneasy.

The only familiar sound she could hear was soft breaths of her sleeping sister.

Salem looked up to the orange sky, and stared at the only cloud drifting through. *What would it be like to look down on this city from so high above?*

A gentle tug pulled her from her thoughts.

Her younger brother stood awkwardly, clutching a stuffed bear.

"Julian? What's wrong?" Salem asked gently.

"I can't sleep. I'm... scared."

"It's okay. There's nothing to be afraid of."

"You promise?"

"Yes. It's a normal day," she said, uneasily. "You should go back to sleep for a little bit."

She grabbed his hand, and guided him to his room. Waiting by his door was a large spotted dog, Sir Nard. He followed Salem into the room with his tail tucked between his legs.

As Salem tucked Julian into bed, Sir Nard curled up besides him.

"See, everything will be fine. Sir Nard is going to keep you safe."

She gently closed the door, leaving the two to sleep. She walked through the cramped apartment and stepped into the kitchen. On the fridge was a small calendar that hadn't been updated recently. Salem crossed out day after day until she finally reached June 19.

Her mom had written "return library books" and other small tasks.

Crammed below all of it, Salem had added "middle school graduation."

She still had a few hours before she'd have to start heading there. There wasn't much to do in the house, so Salem grabbed the mailbox keys that hung next to the calendar, and stepped out. The hallway was old, and full of flickering and broken lights. The elevator creaked as it went down.

She stepped out into the small lobby and pushed her way past the heavy metal entrance doors.

It was a cold day, and the breeze that blew through only made it worse. She leaned against the metal mailboxes and watched the city block.

Everything was silent. It was as if even the trees were afraid to make a noise. She stood there for a few minutes just watching. And it felt like someone was watching back.

Like every movement was being observed. Followed. And judged.

She shook her head. *That's crazy, who would be watching?*

She looked up to the cloud that hovered above. *Maybe you're watching*, she joked to the cloud.

Then someone turned the corner. A man wearing a long trench coat, white gloves, sunglasses, and tall leather boots began walking down the street. He walked into the middle of the road, his head turned up to the sky. It seemed like he was also watching the cloud.

Just mind your own business, Salem told herself. She turned around and worked the key into the slot. She opened the mail box to find it full of letters.

She began collecting them, when suddenly a heavy force slammed into her. She fell to the ground and barely caught herself. Pain shot up through her arms, and the letters scattered across the ground.

She rolled over and found the man from before looming over her. Behind the sunglasses, a massive scar ran down his face. He silently watched her.

She froze.

“Sorry about that,” he said gently.

The man knelt down and collected the letters. He tapped them gently on the ground to neaten the pile, and then handed them back to her.

“Thank you?” Salem said as she stood up and brushed herself off.

He nodded.

Now that the man was closer, she could see how detailed his coat was. Gold string covered it, creating patterns of birds, rabbits, hedgehogs, deers, turtles, and moose. On his breast pocket was a pin of a cat with wings, and ram horns. His white gloves were just as detailed, with silver threads creating patterns of otters. A white vial was placed in the center of each gloves, with clear tubes running along the sides, reaching the fingertips.

He waited a second, as if waiting for Salem to say something. He then walked off.

Salem stood stunned for a minute. She watched him turn the corner.

A bird chirped in the distance. Salem looked up and watched a bird swoop down to the ground. It was followed by more pigeons.

A warm gentle breeze blew through and the sun peaked over the apartment building, warming up the block.

Salem looked up to the sky and found the cloud gone.

As she stepped forwards, her foot hit something metallic. She looked down and found a little golden object laying on the ground. It was a golden sleeping cat figure with its tail wrapped around its body and wings folded down. It was the same animal as the pin on the man’s coat. Gears covered the inside of the body and in the center was a clear vial. On its back was a wind-up key.

Was this the man’s?

She looked around the block, seeing if the man would return.

Cars began filling the street and pedestrians walked past Salem. Soon the street was full of life again.

Salem stuffed the cat into her pocket, along with all the letters.

What just happened?

By the time Salem reentered the apartment, the sun had fully risen. Her mother sat at the small kitchen table, scrolling on her phone.

Julian and Imelda, Salem’s younger sister, were in the kitchen packing their lunches.

“How are you feeling?” Salem asked as she hung up the keys.

“I’m feeling less scared,” he said, hugging her closely.

“See, I told you Sir Nard would keep you safe.”

She walked to her room and opened the fire exit window, and stepped onto the emergency stairs, where she watched cars drive past the apartment.

She pulled out her phone and put on her headphones, and watched pedestrians walk along the street. She hoped to see the man, but he never showed up.

The sunlight warmed up the metallic stairs, and lulled Salem to sleep.

A ring started Salem awake. She pulled out her phone and saw an incoming call.

"Where are you?" Alden yelled through the phone when she answered. "School starts in fifteen minutes!"

"Already? I'm coming," she gasped. She scrambled through the window and grabbed her school bag off the bed as she ran through the apartment.

The middle school was old, its bricks breaking down and the metal gates rusting. A thinning crowd of students entered the building. Salem pushed through the crowd. She couldn't afford to be late, not again.

Just as Salem stepped into the classroom, the bell rang. The teacher stared at her silently.

"Looks like birds made a nest in your hair," she commented as Salem walked past.

Mrs. Williams was a short frail woman with small glasses. Her hair was always perfectly brushed, and she wore beautiful gold jewelry. She had never liked Salem, and always seemed to have something to say about her.

Salem quickly shuffled to the back of the room, and sat down next to Alden.

"What happened?" he asked.

"I was sleeping."

A girl sitting behind Salem leaned forwards. "Like always."

"Come on Kayla, not always. Plus, I woke up feeling weird."

"Yeah, me too," Alden said.

"I saw this weird guy-"

"Salem," the teacher interrupted. "Stop talking unless you want to go to the main office."

A girl by the front of the room snickered. Mary sat by the front. She was Mrs. Williams' favorite. Always acted like a sweetheart around the teachers.

"Sorry," Salem murmured.

"It's always you, isn't it," Kayla whispered.

Salem rolled her eyes. "I can't wait to have a new teacher."

"Salem," Mrs. Williams said, "Since you can't stop talking, how about you work by yourself. Everyone else can work with a partner."

Class ended and the lunch room flooded with students. Salem sat alone at a table by the corner of the room. She rotated the golden cat in her hand while she

waited for Kayla and Alden to get their food.

Mary walked up to the table.

"Hey, Salem," she said with an innocent smile. "Could you sit somewhere else? We want to sit here."

"But I was here first. Just sit on the other side of the table."

"Yeah, but not to be rude or anything, but you're weird and we don't want to sit with you."

Why? Salem asked herself. *Why, I left you alone.*

"I was here first," Salem repeated through gritted teeth.

"So?"

Why is it always me? Why? "Why can't you just leave me alone!" she yelled, standing up. "I was here first!"

The room fell silent. Eyes turned to stare at Salem.

"What is going on?" Mrs. Williams asked, quickly walking up to the girls.

"I asked Salem if I could sit at the table, but she yelled at me," Mary said with an innocent smile.

"Salem, that is unacceptable."

"But--"

"Enough," Mrs. Williams interrupted. "I will not tolerate you treating Mary this way. Apologize to her."

"But she started it!" Salem protested.

"Salem, apologize now, or we'll be taking a walk to the office."

"Sorry, Mary," Salem sighed.

"Good, now why don't you sit somewhere else," Mrs. Williams suggested.

Salem marched to a smaller table with three chairs. She sat down and almost pulled out the cat, when a familiar person grabbed one of the chairs.

It was Mary.

"Wait," Salem said, mindful to keep her voice level. "My friend is going to use it."

"You have friends?" she asked, a wicked smile crossing her face as she walked away with the chair.

Alden and Kayla walked up to the table holding their lunches.

"You couldn't find a table with enough chairs?" Kayla joked.

"Don't mention it," Salem said, standing up. "You two sit down, I'm not hungry."

As Kayla and Alden ate, Salem paced around the table, feeling the golden cat in her pocket.

"What's wrong?" Alden asked.

"So you know how this morning, everything felt weird."

"No," Kayla responded defensively.

"I noticed," Alden said.

“I think I know what caused it.” She placed the cat on the table for the two to see.

“What is this?” Kayla asked.

“Some sort of toy maybe?”

“I met a weird guy and he dropped this. He was wearing a pin with the same animal.”

“What happens if you turn the key?” Kayla asked.

Salem turned the key a few times and placed it back on the table. The three watched as the key slowly unwound. Then, with a soft click, the machines started to open up.

It unwrapped its tail, extending it backwards, as its wings stretched out. With its body no longer covered by its wings, the group could see the cat’s six legs. It arched downwards, and stretched out its front paws, letting out a yawn. For a second it looked up at Salem with beady black eyes.

Then it leapt at Salem! She ducked down, barely dodging it. It stretched out its wings and glided to the other side of the cafeteria, landing under an empty chair.

Salem ran across the room, but before she could grab it, another student picked up the chair. The machine clung on the leg of the chair as it was carried to a table. As the student placed down the chair, Salem took it from him and turned it around. She grabbed the mechanical cat, but it twisted between her fingers and bit down on her hand.

Salem let go by instinct.

The machine ran across the cafeteria, to the table where Mary sat and jumped onto her. It climbed up her back and started going up her hair.

Mary shrieked. “There’s something in my hair!” She twisted around, trying to grab it. It went higher and higher up her hair as Mary began jumping around.

“What’s going on?” Mrs. Williams asked, running up to the scene.

Mary flailed her arms around, and whacked Mrs. Williams in the face. She grabbed Mary’s arms, trying to calm her down. The creature then jumped from Mary’s head to Mrs. Williams’ arm, and went up her sleeves. Mrs. Williams started waving her arms around as well and bumped into Mary, pushing her to the ground.

The creature then popped its head out from Mrs. Williams’ shirt and jumped, landing back on Mary’s hair. It hung in front of her face. Her eyes widened and she froze, as she watched the creature swing back and forth as it hung from her bangs. It then bit down on her hair, cutting it in an uneven way.

It fell to the ground, twisting itself to land on its feet. It then ran under a table, disappearing from sight.

“Over there!” exclaimed Alden, pointing to the cafeteria entrance.

The entire room turned their attention to the door, but the cat had already slipped under.

Salem ran to the door, Alden and Kayla following behind her. She pushed

through, and watched as it ran down the hallway. Salem quickly caught up to it, the creature's short legs not taking it very far.

She picked it up carefully.

"Salem!" Mrs. Williams yelled as the cafeteria door opened.

Salem spotted a janitor's closet. "There!"

The three ran in, and swiftly closed it behind them. They huddled as far from the door as possible. Footsteps quickly approached. The three held their breath. The light from under the door went dark. Then it reappeared as she continued walking.

The three let out a sigh and turned their attention to the machine in Salem's hand. It had wrapped itself up with its tail and seemed to be sleeping.

"Is it alive?" Alden asked.

"I think it's a robot," Salem said. "Maybe we should turn the key again to turn it on?"

"No!" Alden and Kayla hissed.

Kayla gently tapped the cat.

The mechanical cat opened its eyes and stared at the three of them, unblinking. Then it let out a yawn again, revealing a paper tongue that said 'pull'.

Salem hesitantly grabbed the paper, looking to Kayla and Alden for guidance.

"Go on," Kayla urged.

She gently pulled it, unraveling a red strip of paper.

"It's blank?"

"Let me see," Kayla said, grabbing the machine. Suddenly, a small pencil dropped down from the top of the machine's mouth and began writing on the paper:

Hello Future Student Kayla Olafur,

Congratulations!

With great honor, I'm pleased to announce you've been admitted into the
TORRHEX ALLIANCE SCHOOLS

Whether you just want to become a great occultist, change the world, or just
further your career, the schools have it all here for the taking.

Please report to a launch pad by the last day of the Summer Solstice month to
be transported to the center
TORRHEX RESEARCH SPACE STATION

We look forward to you joining this wonderful and historical community of
occultists!

The closest launch site to you is Shopping Center 2039.5. The wampus will lead

you there.

Sincerely,
Head Coven Master Hadeon
Vice Head Coven Master Villanelle

“Kayla, what is that place?” Salem asked.

“I have no idea. I’ve never heard of it.”

The door swung open behind them. “What are you three doing?” Mrs. Williams said. Her hair was a mess and her usually well kept clothing was dirty with chocolate milk.

Salem sat in the principal's office, her head bowed.

“What were you thinking?” Mrs. Williams yelled.

“I was just looking at something,” Salem whispered.

“In the janitor’s closet? And dragging your friends to skip lunch!”

“I won’t do it again,” Salem mumbled. “I just got curious.”

“Well there’s a time and place for you to be ‘curious’. You can’t just investigate everything you’d like. There are consequences to your actions!”

“But since today is the last day,” the principal spoke up, “We’ll let you off with a warning. High school won’t be as forgiving, so please mind you actions.”

“That’s it?” Mrs. Williams exclaimed.

“I don’t think any of us would like to stay here longer than we must. Salem, take this as your lucky day.”

Salem nodded her head and left the room. When she shut the door behind her, she leaned against the door to listen to the conversation start up between Mrs. Williams and the principal.

“That’s all she gets? No reprimands? Nothing else?” Mrs. Williams exclaimed.

“Salem has had some rough few years,” he explained.

“She’s a troubled kid. The teachers have been too lenient. She almost failed math! The highest she got was a C! No Bs or As. That kid isn’t going to learn if you don’t teach her a lesson!”

“Punishment isn’t going to help her,” he continued. “She’s doing her best. She’s different.”

“She’s a hassle,” Mrs. Williams muttered.

Salem quickly walked away from the office door as Mrs. Williams footsteps approached, and stepped outside.

“Hey, Salem!” Alden called from the street.

He ran up to her and put his phone up to her face.

“We know where to start,” Kayla explained. “There used to be an old library

called Torrhhex. It was burnt down in the 1600's but that's the best place to start."
"Great! Let's go."

Chapter 2: A Lonely Flower in an ally way